DUCTS ON CALL · MADISON, WISCONSIN

The Furnace-Season Indoor Air Checklist

Ten things to check before your furnace runs all winter, based on EPA, CDC, U.S. Fire Administration and Wisconsin DHS guidance. Prepared by Nick Bellino, NADCA-certified Air Systems Cleaning Specialist.

DO THESE FIRST

- [ ] **Replace the furnace filter and check the fit**
  EPA suggests MERV 13 or the highest rating your system can accommodate, replaced frequently. The filter should sit snugly with no gaps around the edges and no bending to fit. **Why: the filter only works when air passes through it, not around it.**

- [ ] **Test every carbon monoxide alarm**
  Press the test button, replace batteries, and confirm there is an alarm on each level and near sleeping areas. Replace units older than their stated life (usually 7 to 10 years). **Why: a furnace, water heater or attached garage can all produce CO.**

- [ ] **Start a radon test**
  Wisconsin DHS reports about 1 in 10 homes has elevated radon, and closed-house winter conditions make the heating season the right time to test. Short-term kits cost about $15 to $30. **Why: you cannot see, smell or guess radon.**

- [ ] **Check indoor humidity**
  Put a $10 hygrometer in the main living area and one in the basement. EPA's range is 30% to 50%. Above 60% feeds mold and dust mites; well below 30% means dry skin, static and cracked trim. **Why: humidity is the one number that predicts mold.**

- [ ] **Clean the dryer vent**
  Pull the dryer out, clear the transition duct, and check that the outside hood flap opens freely when the dryer runs. The U.S. Fire Administration lists failure to clean as the leading factor in home dryer fires. **Why: lint plus heat plus a blocked vent.**

THEN LOOK AT THE SYSTEM ITSELF

- [ ] **Run the furnace and smell the first cycle**

  A brief dusty smell at the first start is normal. A musty, sour or burning-plastic smell that returns on every cycle is not; it points to moisture in the ducts, a dirty coil, or a motor problem. **Why: odors you only notice when the blower runs are coming from the system.**

- [ ] **Look inside a supply register and a return grille**

  Lift a floor register and shine a light down. Light dust is normal. Caked debris, drywall dust from a renovation, pet hair mats, visible mold or evidence of mice meet EPA's criteria for having ducts cleaned. **Why: EPA says clean ducts when there is visible mold, vermin or excessive debris, not on a calendar.**

- [ ] **Confirm bath and kitchen fans vent outdoors**

  Hold a tissue to the grille; it should pull firmly. In the attic, check that the duct actually reaches the roof or wall cap rather than ending in the insulation. Run bath fans 20 minutes after showers. **Why: a fan that dumps into the attic grows mold there.**

- [ ] **Clear the mechanical room**

  Keep three feet around the furnace and water heater free of storage, paint, solvents and laundry. Make sure the combustion air opening is not blocked. **Why: combustion appliances need air, and stored chemicals get pulled into the airstream.**

- [ ] **Schedule the professional checks**

  An annual furnace tune-up by an HVAC technician, and a duct inspection if any item above raised a flag. Ask for before-and-after photos of the inside of the ducts, and be wary of a "$99 whole house" offer. **Why: NADCA's standard is to inspect the air handler yearly and ductwork about every two years.**

Not sure what you found? Nick will look for free.

Every Ducts On Call job starts with a free inspection, and if your ducts do not need cleaning, you will be told so. Call or text **(608) 906-1008**, 7 AM to 7 PM, or request an inspection at **ductsoncall-hub.github.io/ductsoncall-madison**. Dryer vent cleaning is a flat $175; duct cleaning is quoted per system after the inspection.

Sources: EPA, "What is a MERV rating?" and "Guide to Air Cleaners in the Home"; EPA, "Should You Have the Air Ducts in Your Home Cleaned?"; EPA Mold Course Chapter 2 (humidity 30 to 50%); Wisconsin Department of Health Services radon program; U.S. Fire Administration, clothes dryer fire data; NADCA ACR Standard. This checklist is educational and is not medical advice. Duct cleaning has not been shown by EPA to prevent health problems; it is appropriate when there is visible mold, vermin or excessive debris. © 2026 Ducts On Call Inc.